

Presentation Notes

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May 29 , 2026

5) Important things to know about the culture for the professional interaction

a) Discuss aspects that one should be aware of when dealing with different cultures in a professional context in order to work together successfully, e.g. as a representative of a company and negotiating partner or as colleagues working together or as in a relationship employee or employer.

Speaker Notes: For the main introduction

- Before we unpack the business specificities, we need to understand the cultural roots that shape how people from these two incredible nations think, act, and communicate.
- As you can see from the vibrant cultural expressions highlighted on the slide, Cameroon is often described as ‘Africa in miniature’ because it packs over 250 diverse ethnic groups into one country. Its social fabric is built entirely on community ties and strict respect for elders.
- Thousands of miles away, Sri Lanka features an equally deep heritage rooted in centuries of South Asian traditions, where family collectivism and maintaining social harmony are the gold standards.
- While their geography and histories differ, both societies teach individuals to place the group before the self and to deeply respect authority. Let’s see how these organic roots play out in the workplace.

Speaker Notes:

- Before we map data, we must understand how cultural differences manifest in the real business world. As the infographic on the slide displays, true intercultural communication relies on a continuous cycle of listening actively, showing empathy, and avoiding rigid stereotyping.
- In a negotiation setting, you have to know if your partner values personal trust or a fast contract first.
- When working as colleagues, friction usually comes from communication styles—what one person considers ‘honest feedback,’ another might experience as an aggressive insult.
- Finally, in an employer-employee relationship, hierarchy defines everything. A manager from a flat culture might expect employees to take independent initiative, while an employee from a hierarchical culture might wait for explicit, step-by-step instructions out of respect. Recognizing these invisible boundaries is what prevents workplace projects from completely derailing.

b) Discuss the impact of specific different cultural rules or cultural related behaviour in various aspects on professional cooperation or negotiation situations. What is the reason or background for this behaviour?

Speaker Notes:

- To truly master cross-cultural cooperation, we have to look past the surface actions and understand the ‘why’ behind the behavior.
- Take communication. When a partner from an indirect culture nods and says ‘yes,’ a Westerner hears an official agreement. But the root cause here is collectivist face-saving—the ‘yes’ simply means ‘I am listening and respecting our interaction.’ Pushing for immediate, blunt clarity can actually damage the deal.
- The same goes for hierarchy. If a colleague seems passive or hesitates to take the lead, it’s rarely a lack of competence. The root cause is high power distance; they are showing deep respect for your position by waiting for explicit direction.

- Finally, skipping the small talk to jump straight into a spreadsheet destroys trust in relationship-first cultures. In their eyes, you don't do business with a corporate logo—you do business with a person.

d) After the discussion in your team, focus for the presentation by agreeing upon the 3-5 most important aspects that you consider as critical success factors or most interesting in this specific intercultural interaction constellation to go further with, presented and discussed in your coursework

Speaker Notes:

- After evaluating how these distinct cultural dynamics clash and align, our team synthesized our findings into four critical success factors for this specific interaction constellation.
- First, we must stop treating cultural data as absolute truth. Success starts when we use frameworks as a conversation starter, not a box to put people in.
- Second, to navigate Power Distance, we have to actively build psychological safety. If we want honest feedback from everyone, leadership must create structured, low-stakes spaces where speaking up doesn't feel like an act of disrespect.
- Third, project workflows must be hybrid—respecting the individualist demand for clear, written accountability while leveraging the collectivist superpower of shared community support.
- Finally, we have to accept that building a human relationship isn't a waste of time. In this constellation, a solid personal bond is the exact engine that drives professional success

6) Cultural dimensions of Hofstede

a) Study at first individually on the cultural dimensions of Hofstede and work on the referring task provided in Moodle (additional source: Hofstede, Geert (2010): Cultures and Organizations - Software of the Mind); <https://www.theculturefactor.com>)

Speaker Notes:

- To kick things off, let's look at the tool grounding our analysis today: Hofstede's Cultural Dimensions. Developed from massive global research, this framework acts as a roadmap for decoding human behavior. It takes the invisible unwritten rules of society—like how we view authority, handle teamwork, or prioritize success—and translates them into metrics we can analyze.
- But instead of just repeating textbook statistics, this presentation does something more critical. We are putting Hofstede to the test by directly comparing his official national data against my own personal, lived cultural experience. This will show us where the framework gets it right, where it falls short, and how these dynamics impact us in a global environment.

Speaker Notes:

- Before we jump into the charts, let's introduce the two nations anchoring our study today: Cameroon and Sri Lanka. On the surface, they might seem completely worlds apart—one sitting in the heart of Central Africa and the other a tropical island nation in South Asia.
- However, they share some incredibly rich common ground. Both societies are built on deep-seated traditional values, vibrant community structures, and complex histories that heavily influence how their people navigate everyday life. By looking at these two specific cultures side-by-side, we create a fascinating testing ground to see if a macro-framework like Hofstede's can truly map the lived realities of two completely different corners of the world.

b) Discuss the cultures involved using the **individually completed tables** (see previous point) on this basis, agree to cover only four out of the six dimensions in your coursework those that you find most insightful for comparison. During the presentation, **briefly explain why you chose these four and not the other two.**

- **Chosen Dimensions:** We chose these four dimensions because they represent the most significant 'cultural gaps' between the societies we are studying. They provide the clearest explanation for differences in family life, economic behavior, and social happiness.
- **Omitted Dimensions:** uncertainty Avoidance (UAI) and Long-Term Orientation (LTO).
 - **UAI:** Sri Lanka and Cameroon share similar lower-to-moderate risk profiles; both cultures manage uncertainty through communal networks and resilience rather than rigid institutional planning.
 - **LTO:** High conceptual overlap with the Collectivism and Achievement axes, leading to analytical redundancy.
- **Only thing remaining is the individually completed tables.**

c) Create a scheme of visualization for the four selected cultural dimensions that can optimally represent the core messages graphically to be integrated in your slides for the presentation. Each cultural dimension should be considered separately. You can use Excel for this, but you can also find other creative means of visualisation. This graphic representation should not only reflect your personal perception, but best step by step integrates the other assessments (see next points). So that you can gradually create a comprehensive comparison integrating different aspects - that is easy to understand and visually supports what you are saying in your presentation in class.

- **Power Distance Speaker Notes:** As you can see on the chart, this is an area of deep alignment. Both cultures naturally respect formal authority. In a university context like HSRW, this means students from both backgrounds fundamentally respect academic boundaries and the hierarchical roles of professors and staff.
- **Individualism vs. Collectivism Speaker Notes:** While both bars lean heavily toward a collective mindset, the visual gap shows that Cameroon's group dependency is even stronger. Sri Lankan collectivism is deeply anchored in extended family networks, whereas Cameroonian collectivism broadens into massive communal and financial safety nets, like the traditional Njangi systems.
- **Motivation towards Success Speaker Notes:** This graph is practically mirror-perfect. Neither culture is overly aggressive or purely driven by individualistic competition. Instead, both student bodies value cooperation, maintaining strong social relationships, and balancing academic success with quality of life.
- **Indulgence vs. Restraint** Our final visual shows a clear contrast in social outlook. Cameroon's higher score reflects an indulgent cultural framework that values open emotional expression, celebration, and leisure. Sri Lanka's lower score indicates a more restrained environment where social duties and traditional norms often guide personal impulses.

d) Explain in your presentation, why you perceive your culture the way you do. (Give two specific examples from everyday life that illustrate your assessment)

Speaker Notes:

- To understand why I perceive Cameroon this way, we have to look at daily life, where these dimensions actually live.

- First, our deep collectivism isn't a textbook theory—it's seen in our traditional Njangi system. Instead of using rigid banks, community circles pool money monthly and hand it to a member based entirely on an honor system. It teaches you early on that the group is your safety net.
- Second, our lean toward indulgence shows up in how we celebrate. Life and milestones happen out in the open, with high emotional energy and shared public joy, proving that we prioritize relationships and resilience over rigid structures.

That is why I view my culture as deeply interconnected and expressive.

e) In addition to your personal view, add Hofstede's results to your graphical visualization <https://www.theculturefactor.com> ; see chapter 'country comparison tool' provided on the page and study his argumentation coming to this assessment.

- This has already been answered in part C).

f) Also indicate whether you agree with Hofstede's findings. Why or why not? Critically discuss: What might be problems with his approach? What might be problems with your approach?

Speaker Notes:

- To address parts E and F of the assignment, do I agree with Hofstede's assessment? For the most part, no. The graphs expose a massive disconnect between my lived reality and his textbook data. I experience my culture as deeply communal and highly expressive, yet Hofstede's numbers paint a picture of a hyper-individualistic, restrained society.
- This gap perfectly highlights the limitations of both methods. Hofstede's approach suffers from a rigid corporate bias—his framework was built on office workers decades ago, meaning it completely flattens complex, real-world social fabrics into a single nationwide average.
- Conversely, the problem with my approach is that it's a subjective sample size of one. My view is limited to my own upbringing, which can easily confuse personal family values with a national rule. Ultimately, this comparison proves that macro-statistics often fail to capture the true human experience.

g) In addition, based on the same cultural dimensions chosen, discuss how you perceive Rhine-Waal University organizational and work culture; focusing on academic staff and administration and not on students. Give two specific examples to support your assumptions. Since there is no official Hofstede score, add the German graph to compare

Speaker Notes:

- To wrap up, do we agree with these findings? Broadly, yes. The massive contrast on our graphs—like Individualism jumping from 20 in Cameroon to 90 at HSRW—perfectly captures the real shock of moving from a highly communal society into an independent European academic environment.
- However, we have to look at this critically. The problem with Hofstede's approach is that it reduces millions of people to a single national average. In Cameroon, regional and tribal differences are massive, which a single score completely flattens.
- Furthermore, our own approach has limitations. HSRW is a progressive, international university bubble—it doesn't represent standard German culture. By comparing a diverse country to a specific campus environment using proxy data, our sample size is small and heavily biased. It's a useful map, but not the whole territory.

h) Conclude and discuss the implications when these cultures involved come together in a professional context (at our university). If there are areas where potential problems or misunderstandings may arise. Discuss and make suggestions how best to deal with them.

Speaker Notes:

- To conclude, what happens when these two cultural realities collide right here on campus? The friction shows up in two main areas: hierarchy and teamwork.
- With Power Distance, a student used to high hierarchy might avoid challenging a professor or speaking up in a seminar. In a flat-hierarchy system like Germany's, this can be misread as a lack of preparation. With Individualism, group work can derail quickly. Individualists want to slice a project into pieces and work alone; collectivists want to tackle it fluidly as a tight unit.
- To solve this, we shouldn't just hope for the best. Teams need to set explicit, written individual tasks on day one, while building in communal feedback loops. Understanding these differences turns potential frustration into a massive collaborative advantage